

Aquatic Therapy for Arthritis: More Than Just Swimming

Hydrotherapy and aquatic exercise provide unique benefits for arthritis.
Discover NHS-available options and exercises you can do at your local pool.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-10 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Why Water Works Wonders
Water provides a unique therapeutic environment: buoyancy reduces joint loading by up to 90%, warmth relaxes muscles and increases blood flow, and hydrostatic pressure reduces swelling. The Arthritis Foundation rates aquatic exercise as one of the top recommended activities.

Types of Aquatic Therapy

NHS Hydrotherapy - Conducted in warm pools

(33-36°C) - Led by specialist physiotherapists

- Available via GP or consultant referral

- Sessions typically 30-45 minutes

Community Pool Exercises

You do not need a referral to benefit. Try

these at your local leisure centre:

1. **Water walking**: Walk forward, backward and sideways in chest-deep water (10 minutes)

2. **Leg swings**: Hold pool edge, swing leg forward and back (2 × 10 per leg)

3. **Arm circles**: Submerged to shoulders, make slow circles (2 × 15)

4. **Water squats**: Feet shoulder-width, squat to chair height (2 × 10)

5.

****Flutter kicks**:** Hold edge, gentle kicks (2 × 30 seconds)\n\n**### Finding Facilities**\n- Search 'hydrotherapy near me' on the CSP (Chartered Society of Physiotherapy) website\n- Many leisure centres offer arthritis-friendly sessions\n- Water temperature matters: look for pools heated to at least 30°C\n\n***Programme designed by James Walker, Aquatic Physiotherapy Specialist, MCSP***



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What the Evidence Says

Leading clinical guidelines for managing various forms of arthritis consistently highlight the benefits of aquatic exercise. Numerous systematic reviews, which gather and analyse findings from multiple high-quality studies, including randomised trials, suggest that regular activity in water can significantly improve pain, stiffness, and physical function for people with conditions like osteoarthritis and rheumatoid arthritis. These improvements can lead to a better quality of life and may even reduce the need for pain relief medication.

The consistent message from research is that engaging in aquatic therapy should be considered a core part of a comprehensive management plan for arthritis. While the exact mechanisms are still being explored, the combination of warmth, buoyancy, and resistance offered by water appears to create a uniquely effective environment for exercise, particularly for those who find land-based activities challenging due to joint pain and instability.

Common Mistakes to Avoid



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* **Doing too much too soon:** Start with short sessions and gentle movements, gradually increasing duration and intensity as your body allows. * **Ignoring pain:** Differentiate between muscle fatigue and joint pain; if an exercise causes sharp or increasing joint pain, stop and rest. * **Not using correct form:** Focus on controlled, smooth movements rather than speed to protect your joints and maximise benefits. * **Not staying hydrated:** Even in water, you can become dehydrated, so drink plenty of water before and after your session. * **Discontinuing when feeling better:** To maintain benefits, aquatic exercise needs to be a consistent part of your routine, even when symptoms are well-controlled.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While aquatic exercise is generally safe and beneficial, there are times when it's important to speak with your doctor, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist before starting or continuing. This is especially true if you experience new or worsening symptoms, or if you have other health conditions that might be affected by water-based activity.

* You develop new, unexplained joint swelling or severe pain. * You have an open wound, skin infection, or specific medical conditions like uncontrolled epilepsy or heart problems. * You experience dizziness, unusual shortness of breath, or chest pain during or after exercising in water. * Your existing pain significantly increases, or your joint function worsens despite regular aquatic exercise. * You are unsure whether aquatic exercise is suitable for your specific type of arthritis or other health issues.



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Frequently Asked Questions

Is warm water necessary, or is a regular unheated pool okay? While warmer water (ideally 30-36°C) offers additional benefits like muscle relaxation and improved blood flow, you can still gain considerable advantages from exercising in a standard heated swimming pool. The buoyancy and resistance of the water remain beneficial regardless of temperature, so don't let mild temperature be a barrier.

How often should I do aquatic exercises to see results? For most people with arthritis, aiming for two to three sessions of aquatic exercise per week is a good starting point. Consistency is key, so try

to make it a regular part of your routine. You may start to notice improvements in pain and mobility within a few weeks to a couple of months.

Can aquatic exercise help with all types of arthritis? Yes, aquatic exercise is generally recommended for various forms of arthritis, including osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis, and fibromyalgia. The reduced impact on joints makes it particularly suitable for people experiencing pain and stiffness, offering a way to exercise safely and effectively that might be difficult on land.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about aquatic therapy for arthritis: more than just swimming?

Short answer: Aquatic therapy for arthritis uses water's buoyancy to reduce joint loading by up to 90%, warmth to relax muscles, and hydrostatic pressure to reduce swelling. NHS hydrotherapy, in pools of 33-36°C, is led by specialist physiotherapists for 30-45 minutes. Community pool exercises like water walking and leg swings can be done in pools heated to at least 30°C, ideally two to three times per week.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.